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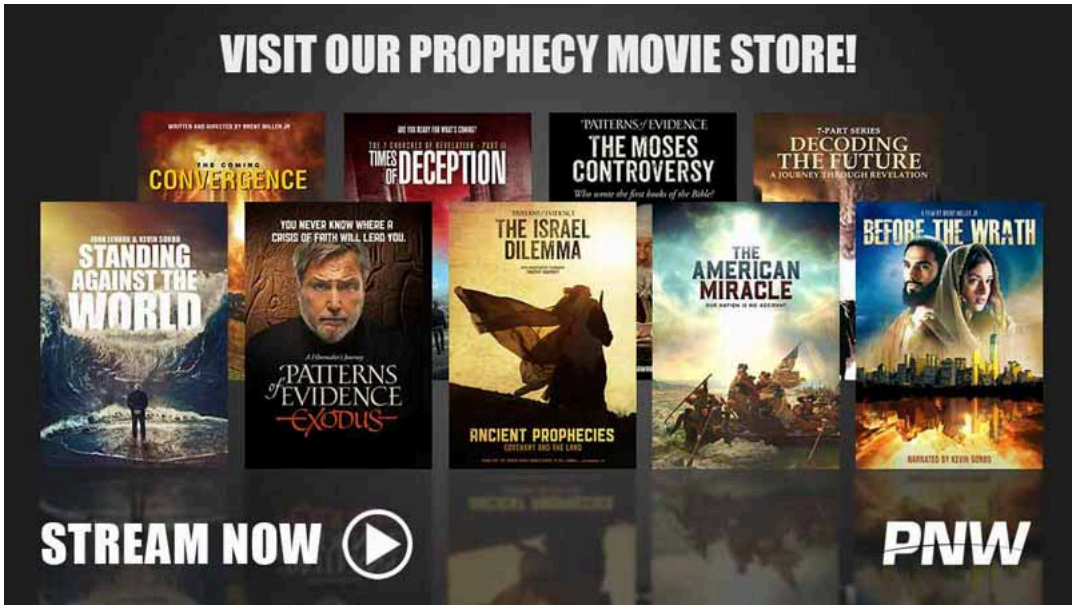

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ARTICLE

A World Preparing For War – Global Military Spending Surges

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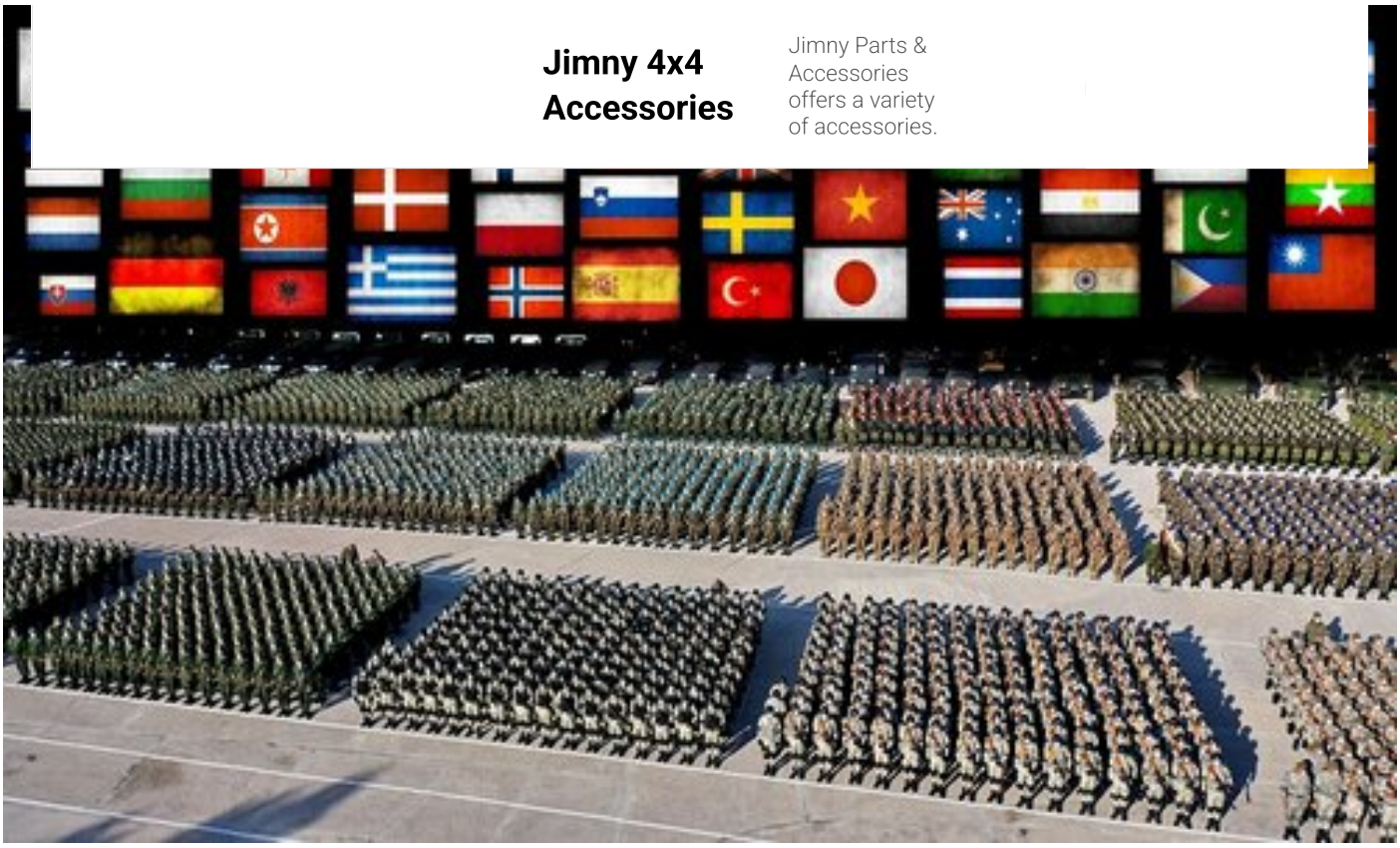

BY PNW STAFF APRIL 29, 2026

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There are moments in history when numbers stop being abstract--and start telling a story. The latest report from Stockholm International Peace Research Institute does exactly that. At first glance, a 2.9% rise in global military spending might not sound like much. But step back, and the picture sharpens: nearly $2.9 trillion poured into defense in a single year, representing 2.5% of the entire global economy--the highest share since 2009. That's not just a budget trend. It's a signal.

And the signal is hard to ignore: the world is preparing, quietly but unmistakably, for conflict.

The raw numbers alone are staggering. The United States continues to dominate with $954 billion in spending, followed by China at $336 billion and Russia at $190 billion. But the more revealing story isn't just who spends the most--it's who is accelerating the fastest.

Across Europe, defense budgets surged 14% in just one year, the sharpest increase since the early Cold War era. Countries like Belgium, Spain, and Norway posted increases nearing or exceeding 50%. Germany, long cautious about military expansion, now ranks fourth globally.

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These are not routine adjustments. They are generational shifts.

Why now? Because the global order feels less certain than it has in decades. The war in Ukraine continues to grind on, consuming resources at a historic pace. Ukraine itself is dedicating an astonishing 40% of its GDP to defense--an economic posture that reflects not strategy, but survival. Russia, meanwhile, is committing 7.5% of its GDP, reinforcing the reality that this conflict is far from contained.

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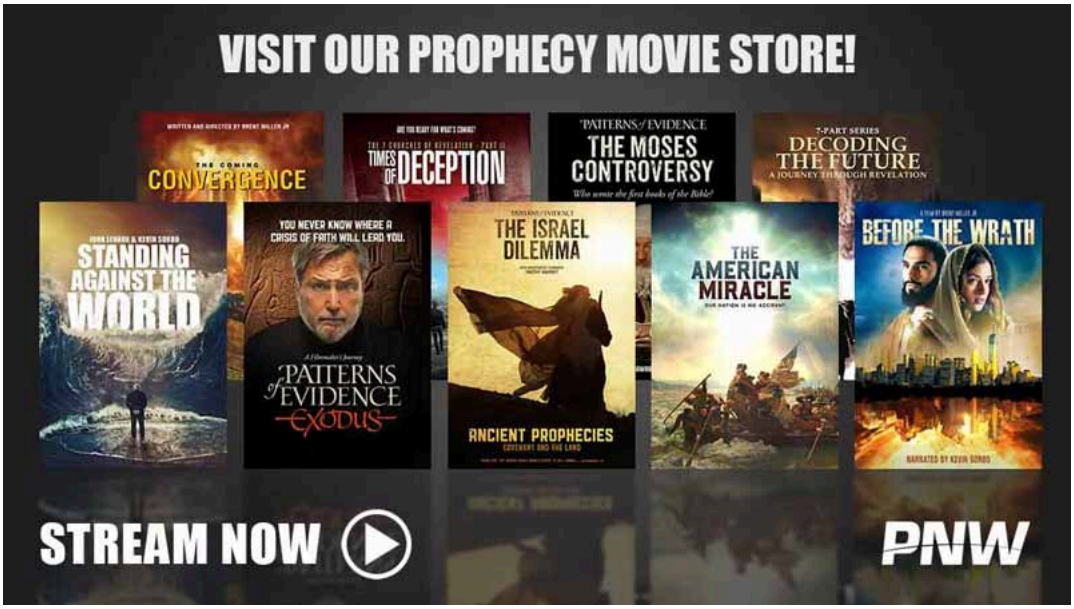
The same pattern is unfolding in Asia.

Japan, historically restrained in its military posture, has reached its highest defense spending as a share of GDP since 1958. Taiwan is boosting its budget at the fastest pace in decades. China, meanwhile, has increased military spending for 31 consecutive years, with a fresh 7.4% jump in 2025 alone. That's not just modernization--it's momentum.



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And then there are the quieter, less headline-grabbing regions. Africa saw an 8.5% increase in military spending. India boosted its defense budget by nearly 9%, driven by tensions with Pakistan. Even in the Middle East, where spending dipped slightly in some areas, underlying realities--like Iran's off-the-books funding mechanisms--suggest the true numbers may be higher than reported.

In other words, this isn't isolated. It's global.

One of the most telling insights from the SIPRI report is what happens when you remove the United States from the equation. Without U.S. spending, global defense expenditures didn't just rise--they surged by 9.2%. That means the rest of the world is ramping up even faster than the headline figures suggest.

This matters because it points to a broader psychological shift. Nations aren't just reacting to current conflicts--they're preparing for future ones. Defense budgets are, in many ways, a reflection of fear, expectation, and anticipation. And right now, those expectations appear to be leaning toward instability.

Even more concerning is what lies ahead. The U.S. has already approved over $1 trillion in defense spending for 2026, with proposals reaching $1.5 trillion for 2027. Ongoing conflicts, including a costly war involving Iran, are accelerating that trajectory. According to projections, 2026 could see even steeper increases worldwide.

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History offers a sobering lesson: large-scale military buildups rarely happen in isolation. They tend to cluster in periods of uncertainty, rivalry, and shifting power balances. Sometimes they act as deterrents. Other times, they become preludes.

Right now, it's too early to say which path the world is on. But the direction is clear.

A world spending nearly $3 trillion on defense isn't just maintaining peace--it's bracing for what might come next.

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